

SELECTED POEMS

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Dedicated to my Mother Sara Elizabeth Sylvester

ANXIETY BEFORE GOD

Today, Lord, I am sorry.

I am sorry I let my body and my mind drain my life
away

From You, the Giver of Life.

I did not pray when the demons wasted me away,
When they boiled me in the cauldron of sin
That poured out enmity upon the world.
I was so afraid that the vision left but traces of
black mud-tracks,
Leading down into the darkest of all rivers.

And there my fragile frame collapsed,
Refusing to rise and glorify Your name.

I am sorry for these things,

And all the others I could have done in order to
reach You –
To honour and know You,
And so to praise You always.

PAIN

How is it that within a single hour
I can go from deliberating my own death at my
hands
To feeling ecstatic at the bliss of living,
At the holy realisation of being alive in an infinite
universe?

I suppose it is as a dark storm claps thunder
And puts the light out,
Only to warm and shine an hour later after sheets
of rain –
The fright expelled by the light.

This is the meaning of my life.
But it is not lived by hours; it is lived by minutes.
And even if the minute is short, it will pass;
It passes, and the pain-free joy is worth living for.

Nothing lasts forever, that lasts for a lifetime.
And though it may be five years from now,
A good time will come.
So keep knowing it will pass,
And nothing else of myself ask.

VIRGIN IN THE MEADOW

I thought I saw the Virgin in a tree.
Perched halfway up in prayer and tunica,
Head bowed, she balanced on the thick stem of a
branch
Where the verdure was ample and lush.

Beneath her mantle was a woad-blue, not quite
brown,
Her face resting in light shadow.
The tree at the end of the vast meadow stood
totally still,
Stark and skeletal in late May.

A field of daffodils lay between us,
And beyond, the deep furrows of barley.
I looked again and still I could not make out the
tree,

But only the Virgin, half-standing peacefully.

What did this mean, by nature's grace?

The purity of nature's healing made evident.

I gripped the rosary around my neck:

Qui ad te confugimus.

Through the meadow and up into the branches,

Your statue is but an apparition –

It passes the moment I move.

SUPINE IN THE MEADOW

The undulating flight of the pigeon over the rolling
hill;

From such height, the dappled yellow of the
meadow is an ocean bed,

And the plump hedgerows viridian reefs.

The new grass is a cushioned landing,

Remaining cool before the late evening dew comes
to bless the land.

The tangled flight of the butterfly passes my eye.

But when I am supine, I see only the thinly veiled
sky –

So cream-coloured it might peel back,

Letting a hand reach through.

A finger beckoning.

It says nature is but one grace; step this way and
see the kingdom.

Its infinite way is a balm of beauty longed for even
by nature itself,
More than by every previous thought of God.

The up and down of life rolls on,
But the life of what is to come is impossible to
detail.

LIGHTNING

In a blip, the sorrow courses from every inner
stream,
Flooding the spirit;
A vice of light and pain where the self is crushed –
’Tis fallen nature’s interminable force.
Yet inside the tabernacle of the mind
A lightning bolt strikes the storm,
Raging, quick, and mortal,
It stings me into the posture of the
deathbed-penitent;
The raw stuff of the slaughter.

My reason rendered dumb
By the world’s many draughts numbed,
By the upward shocks of the Cross stung;
Yet never closer to the *Esse* have I knelt
Than in these absolutely fatigued days of
Being-reliance.

Here, the Almighty reveals the Father's hand,
The cooling comfort of His palms
Breathing the *Pneuma* through the Son.

In a blip, the temporal arrives and departs,
And nothing of the earth can last;
But in the wonderment of linear time –
In the *Chronos* comes the Truth.
How beautiful is the stain that spreads through
history,
The blood of the Son that seeps into the crimson
wound
To ever ease the sting.

DEPRESSION

O Lord, sustain me through these tiring days,
Which drain my soul and leave my spirit dry;
Direct my heart to seek repentant ways,
And grant the blessing of a contrite cry.

Let not my pride desire itself to clone,
And see my foes defeated at my feet;
But let me thirst for heavenly rays alone,
Where peace abides eternal and complete.

The venom of my base desires grows still,
Though deep fatigue and dark depression reign;
Subdue the poison of a wayward will,
That seeks its comfort in a fleeting gain.

Like Job I sit within the ash and dust,

Or like Elijah seek the desert's shade;
Yet in Thy mercy I shall place my trust,
Beneath the light that does not fail or fade.

THE FIRST STROLL OF SPRING

O spring, thy gentle current fills the air,
Thy breezes sting no more but whisper fair;
The birdsong wakes the dawn and holds the hour,
As daylight opens outwards like a flower.
The winter's weeping wetland starts to yield,
And boots walk freely on the drying field.

I stretch my legs across the open grass,
Where newborn lambs against their mothers pass;
Just past the village edge, the pathways run
Beneath the trees, made taller by the sun.
A sudden chill strikes lightly on my brow,
Far sweeter than the heat of summer's vow.

Yet seasons fade, despite their earthly light;
My heart is anchored in the Triune sight,
In Him whose flesh was freely given for all,

To lift this vast creation from the fall.
Like Francis, let me sing the earth's sweet hymn,
And glimpse eternal hope around the field's green
rim.

MY GOD, MY GOD

My God, my God, deliver me from woe,
But lead me not where false redemptions lie;
Preserve me from the cunning of the foe,
Whose whispered snares allure the mourning eye.

Permit Evil not to draw a single pace,
Nor cast his unseen tripwire in the night;
Let not the dark my reason's spark efface,
But keep me ever vigilant in light.

Illumine me with Thine incarnate Son,
And let His blazing torch before me thrust;
Hear Thou the cries of this forsaken one,
Who is slumped at dusk, grieving in the dust.

A restless sting torments this mortal frame

That yearns to lay its weighted yoke down;
Grant me the rest that only bears Thy Name,
And by Thy virtue, wear the blessed crown.
Amen.

GLORIFIED

The fairest forms that mortal eyes behold
Must fade as shadows when the day is done;
But bodies wrought of heaven's finer gold
Outshine the fleeting glory of the sun.

The painter's muse, the poet's worldly dream,
Are but a fracture of the utmost grace;
A thousandfold the seraphim shall gleam,
Reflecting God in His true holy place.

But these dire chains of solitude must break,
And demons of our isolation flee;
When weary, exiled souls at last awake,
And hope to join the saints' festivity.

There in the gathered faithful's radiant throng

The Devil's proud illusions lose their art;
For individual conceits belong
No more to those who share a single heart.

ON THE HILL OF ARES

Amidst the marble gods of olden Greece,
Where ancient minds built altars to the skies,
I sought the Sovereign Lord of truth and peace,
Concealed from wayward and untutored eyes.

Yet silent marble breathed no gentle grace,
But machinations born of wrath and pride;
I found no being in that hollow place,
For sovereignty is bound to Zion's side.

As Paul proclaimed in verse the ancients penned,
We are His offspring, fashioned by His hand;
Though scattered seeds of truth the world attend,
By sin and sacred font we fall or stand.

For in His breath we live and move and are,

The Maker of the earth and vault of heaven;
No graven stone nor solitary star
Can hold the boundless grace that He hath given.

Let fall the veil of ignorance and night,
The Unknown God is manifest in flesh;
Who rose from death arrayed in glorious light
To judge the world and weave our souls afresh.

Lord, purge my heart of all its old desires
That I may build an altar to Thy Name;
To seek the truth Thy Holy Ghost inspires,
And let my pride be swallowed in Thy flame.

HEAVENLY DOVE

Let not my senses slumber, Heavenly Dove,
Who from the Father and the Son proceeds;
Awake my fractured soul to perfect love
And make me whole in holy thoughts and deeds.

The very Breath that stirred the ancient deep
And courses through the corridors of time,
Arouse my being from its mortal sleep
To resonate with unity sublime.

Descend, O blessed Trinity of Grace
And let Thy triune power in me abide;
Make of this fragile frame a dwelling place,
Wherein the Father, Son, and Ghost reside.

PRAYER OF RESPITE

O Lord, my heart is shattered by my sin;
I beg Thee tear this bramble from my flesh.
I will it not, yet find my soul within
The snare of pain and pleasure caught afresh.

If Thine eternal sacrifice be true
And broken bread yields everlasting life,
Then let this Sacred Host my strength renew
To purge my guilt and end this bitter strife.

I yearn to dwell where grace doth freely run,
For unassisted I shall surely fail.
Descend and guide me, O Incarnate Son,
Marooned within this fallen, earthly vale.

Amen.

EMBRACE ME, CHRIST

Embrace me, Christ, upon Thy holy rood;
I cleave unto the timber of Thy cross
And bathe within the fountain of Thy blood,
Wherein the world's vain glory turns to dross.

Draw near my spirit to the piercing nail
That rends the flesh to set the captive free;
When mortal terrors and dark sins assail,
My sole deliverance is forged in Thee.

Keep me enfolded in Thine arms of pain,
Pressed to the Sacred Heart that bleeds for all;
Thy mercies, countless as the springtide rain,
Require my soul's devotion lest I fall.

No earthly measure sums the grace bestowed,

Nor spans the depth of love Thy wounds suffice;
But by the daily prayers to Thee I owe,
May adoration be my humble price.

PRAYER OF EMPTY HANDS

Lord, I have done my work.

I have fought the demons of the day.

I have seen Your grace at work in the faces of
strangers.

I thank them, and I ask forgiveness from any soul I
have harmed.

But I bring You nothing at this night hour

Save these empty hands,

Waiting for Your grace,

For a peaceful end and a joyful rising again.

Amen.

THE LITANY OF RELEASE

From the division of the ego, which fractures the
world into suspicion,
And seeks to divide all things into parts and parcels
of mistrust,
Deliver me, O Lord.

From the tyranny of the will, and the wrongs I do
daily,
Which I hate but perform; and from the lack of
wisdom to know the difference,
Deliver me, O Lord.

From the painful doubts that creep in when the
sun has set,
From the sweat of anxiety that soaks the sheets,
And from the terrors of meaningless visions in the
night,

Deliver me, O Lord.

From the sudden snare of the Enemy, who strikes
when I least expect,
And enflames this life to be a hell, when by Your
Grace it ought to be a heaven,
Deliver me, O Lord.

From the ambition to be known, and the fear of
being forgotten,
From the noise of my own narrative, and the pride
of my own pain,
Deliver me, O Lord.

From the compulsion to voice every pang, concern,
and gripe,
Lest this prayer become too ripened with self, and
too long for honesty;

From the sickness of the self, and the refusal of
silence,
Deliver me, O Lord.

O Lord of all mankind,
Healer of human ails:
Silence the clamour of the I,
That in the quiet,
I may hear the Thou –
Let me be empty, that I might be filled;
Let me be forgotten, that I might be found.

AT THE ABBEY: ANGELUS FLENS

Upon the balustrade of broken stone,
She takes her stand, majestic and alone.
The rain has ceased, the clouds begin to part,
Revealing fire burning in her heart.
She speaks to skeletons and wandering men,
To call the spirit to the world again.

‘Arise, ye hungry, from the mud and clay,
The night has passed, behold the coming day.
You look for crumbs upon the barren floor,
But see, I open up the banquet door.
The Feast is set, not with the bread of old,
But with a mystery the saints foretold.’

‘No longer mourn the pillar and the arch,
Or weep for armies in their cruel march.
The stone is rolled away, the ruins sing,

The winter passes with the breath of spring.
Here in the wreck of history's cruel spite,
The Incarnation bursts into the light.'

'Come, take the seat that waits for you above,
And taste the vintage of Eternal Love.
The blood that stained the ground has washed it
clean,
To make a Kingdom of this broken scene.'

The shadows flee, the crow ascends the sky,
And silence answers to the hunger's cry.
The Abbey stands, no longer grave but womb,
Where Life emerges from the empty tomb.

AT THE ABBEY: UMBRAE CORVI

The shadows of the crow soar overhead,
Above the roofless walls where monks have bled.
The immense abbey church in glory stood,
A temple hewn of stone and holy wood;
Named for the One, the Holy, and the True,
Before the raze of kings and thunder blew.
Now stripped of altars, bare and forbidden,
The sacred mysteries in dust are hidden.

Driven to scattered homesteads, poor and damp,
The religious fled the extinguishing of the lamp.
By wrathful rains and thunderous heavens fed,
They left the sanctuary to the dead.
But one remained, though people fled in fear:
The Weeping Angel, with her brow severe;
And wings bereft, she fell deeply inwards,
To wipe away the chains of tears and words;
She stood quite still, lost in the fearful time,

The only witness to the ancient crime.

The Tower stands, where remedies were brewed
In quiet vales, by nature now subdued.
Here Paradise stood tall in years gone past,
Where purified springs made water that would last.
Voices chanted up through the misty hills
Dispersing grace to cure the peoples' ills.
In dreams one wonders: were the Spirits true?
Or just a mist that morning sunlight slew?

Now murky liquids swallow up God's Word,
Down gutters where the innocent are heard.
The lame, the restless, minds in desperate state
Sit on the sandstone ledge to curse their fate.
Cross-legged, moss-infested, on death's edge,
They call for Mercy from the ruin's ledge;
Until the Angel, landing on the stone,
Prepares to make the final secret known.

THE PILGRIM'S VISION

The thread was lost, the spool had tumbled down,
Ricocheting through the chaotic town.
I was the farmer of a scattered soul,
Who chased the sheep he could no longer control.
My days were spent in hunting distinct thrills,
A wanderer upon the barren hills,
Until I cast my passion on a girl,
Known in the village as the lovely April.

She worked the land with gentle, calloused hands,
The fairest flower in the meadow lands.
I built a temple to her in my mind
And left the love of Heaven far behind.
But earthly love is fragile as the grass;
Her father's greed brought tragic things to pass.
He sold her hand to wealth and high estate,
And left me standing outside the locked gate.
I fell to knees in dirt and dark despair,

And tore the roots of pride out with my hair.
I sought the darkness, wished for sudden death,
To curse the God who gave me living breath.
But as the storm clouds gathered overhead
And I lay waiting amongst the spirit-dead,
The sky broke open with a sudden light
To chase away the demons of the night.

A Lady stood there, clothed in blue and green,
The fairest vision I had ever seen.
She wore the face of April, yet refined –
The earthly love within the soul enshrined.
No longer fickle, flighty, or unsure,
But solid, holy, radiant, and pure.
She spoke, and authority was in her face,
And I knew then her holy name was Grace.

‘You suffer hardship for a foolish youth,’
She said, ‘And turn your back upon the Truth.
You set your heart on love without a proof

And built your house beneath a rotten roof.
You weep for silver loss and earthly wife
But will not weep for your eternal life.'

'Listen,' she said, 'The light of humility
Is greater than your pride's ability.
The rich man climbs the mountain of his gold,
Only to find the summit bleak and cold.
But he who digs the grave and tends the soil,
Shall find a treasure in his honest toil.
Will you condemn yourself to dark and pit,
Or will you let the candle now be lit?'

I raised my head, the mud upon my cheek,
And found the strength that I had come to seek.
The earthly April faded from my view,
Replaced by Love that makes the spirit new.
I took the staff, I left the selfish past,
To walk the pilgrim's journey home at last.

THE NUN OF WATTON

In Yorkshire's vale, where fog and river creep
And Gilbert's daughters ancient vigil keep,
A child was given to the cloister's door,
To wed a God she did not yet adore.
She grew in habit, but her heart was wild,
A woman trapped within the holy child;
No prayer could tame the blood that ran beneath
The human spirit struggling in its sheath.

A lay brother, with eyes of earthly fire,
Awoke the embers of a forbidden desire.
Beneath the walls where shadows hide the sin
They let the darkness and the passion in.
But secrets in a convent cannot last,
The belly swells, the die is surely cast;
The sisters found her, stripped of grace and name,
And turned their pious love to burning shame.

They chained her deep within a narrow cell,
To make her prison mirror Satan's hell.
They caught the lover, dragged him to the room
To meet a cruel and bloody, distinct doom.
They placed the knife within her trembling hand
And forced the deed their vengeance did
command;
O horror! That a lover's hand should maim,
To wash away the convent's stained name.

In fetters then she lay, in dark despair,
With nothing left but agony and prayer.
But in the night when hope had surely fled,
A light appeared beside her stony bed.
The chains that bound her ankles, rusted deep,
Fell silent to the floor while others sleep;
The miraculous glow of the Redeemer's face
Dissolved the iron with a sudden grace.

Saint Aelred came, the Abbot wise and old,
To see this wonder in the story told.
He saw the chains, the woman free of band,
And saw the work of God's mysterious hand.
He silenced those who sought to judge her sin,
For God had cleansed the ruin from within.
What God has touched, let no man call unclean,
A mercy found where only sin had been.

O SOUL, THEE BE SETTLED

O Lord,

This life is never settled.

I pray and I hope, yet I always worry.

My peace is sieged by interruptions, threats,
mistakes, and all manner of grief.

For the moments where I must offer forgiveness,
and for the patience required to meet this day,

I beseech Thee, O Lord, to grant me grace through
Jesus Christ.

He is Your Anointed Son, the Messiah, and my
heart's deepest desire.

He revealed most generously, unto the most painful
death of the Cross,

The Truth, the Way, and the Life.

He is True Light from Light,

True Conqueror of Death from Death,

Transforming the darkest darkness into the most
joyful of radiating lights.

Let that Light stabilise my unsettled soul today,
I pray.

Amen.

THE WRITER'S PERSERVERANCE

Come, O Lord,
Have mercy on my vanity and the ambitions that
seek only their own Will.
Come and aid my pen, which hopes to inspire the
world.
Grant my storytelling the wisdom of Your Truth,
And the patience to know it and persevere through
all pitfalls.

Come, O Lord, and work through me.
I beg and beseech Thee: do not let my pen be led
astray.
Let me write nothing that is false to the human
spirit,
And nothing that is contrary to Your Glory.

THE MIRE OF VICTIMHOOD

My Majesty, the Messiah,
My soul is sorrowful to the point of despair;
I have spent the night groaning in prayer.
My kindness has been betrayed and judged ill.
But Lord, I confess: this is naught compared to
Your Passion, whence blood was copiously spilled.
In my grief, I have not been spat on by my own
brothers, nor despised,
Nor led away to death, nor nailed to any kind of
Cross.

So let me sin no more against Thee by nursing this
grievance.
In my own deep valley of pity, save me.
Hoist me from the mire of my own victimhood
that threatens to consume me entirely.
Scourge me free from the hands of Satan.
Shove me from his grip,

Stamp me to the ground in humility,
That I may not glorify the Evil One with my
despair.
Let me rise, not in pride, but in gratitude for what I
have been spared.

PASCE ME

Christe, pasce me gratia tua.

Christe, pasce me ne esuriam,

Pasce me, ut in bello roborer,

Pasce me, ut amem sicut Tu amasti,

Et nuntiem gloriam tuam

De summis culminibus huius vitae in terra.

Amen.

Christ, feed me with your grace.

Christ, feed me so that I may not hunger,

Feed me so that I may be strong in battle,

Feed me so that I may love as you have loved,

And that I may proclaim your glory

From the highest summit of this life on earth.

Amen.

THAT STRANGE ACT OF WRITING

I do not know what to do with this grief,
So I put pen to paper –
That strange, ancient act of communicating with
oneself,
A tether when the mind reels,
Drawn in by a sadness not vast, but intense,
Specific as a face I can no longer touch.

How fortunate is the one who writes,
For when the world offers no distraction
And the silence is too loud with absence,
The ink becomes a movement, a way to breathe.
I have no profound insights to offer the dark,
Only the dull ache of a rupture,
The mystery of why human bonds must break,
Why the narrative ends in destruction
When we only wanted the story to last.

I look to the mountain and see the Law,
The stone demands given to Moses –
True, yes, and beautiful in their terror,
A height we were meant to climb.
But I know, too, the weakness of our knees;
We cannot meet the demand. We never could.

And so, the Son.
The true person of God, entering the rupture,
Not to condemn the fracture but to fill it.
He knows we entered this world broken,
That we are nothing but sinners,
And whispers that it is – if not good –
Then understood.

It is not God who holds the whip now, but us.
We are the ones who castigate,
We, the jailers of our own spirits,
Whilst He stands at the door, open.

If we could but be kind to our own fragility,
We might finally be kind to another,
And snap the iron cycle of conflict.

To choose mercy, as He chose it,
To refuse the impulse to punish –
O, how great the fount that springs from thence!
A reconciliation of waters,
Where we call each other blessed,
And the sadness is washed into the sea.

EMPTY IN MADRID

There was a time, not long ago,
When chanting thoughts moved to and fro.
I sat upon a bench of stone,
In Madrid's heat, but chilled to bone.
Beside the gallery's artful grace
I looked for God but found no trace.
By luminous fountains in the May
I watched the water dance and play,
But my own mind was dry and bare
And found no living Spirit there.

Immature as a mule, I spoke
And tried to cast off faith's old yoke:
'Speak to me now, if You exist!'
But silence rose up a sore mist.
And God said 'No' – or so I thought –
For in that void my soul was caught.
The emptiness felt absolute,

The heavens stayed entirely mute.
I swore that Faith was dead and gone,
A light that never truly shone.

And yet, beneath that layer of gray,
A deeper truth in ambush lay.
For Faith can sleep within the ash,
Hidden from the lightning flash.
It does not die, it merely waits
Behind the soul's locked iron gates.

For here I am, though years have flown,
And seeds of truth are fully grown.
Though ecstasy has dampened down
And age has woven a heavier crown,
My knowledge is no greater now,
Yet Faith is stamped upon my brow –
Truer than visions, deep and vast,
Anchored in the silent past.

How crafty, Lord, to hide Your face!
To feign Your death in time and space,
To let me feel the sting of loss,
The heavy silence of the Cross.
You hid within the deepest cave
To show me that I could not save
Myself by feelings or by sight,
But only by the inner light.

Now rise, You thousand Phoenixes!
Rise from the mind's recesses!
Shout down the voice of ancient doubt
And let the Risen Christ cry out.
The Trumpet sounds! The silence breaks!
The God within the spirit wakes!
He lives in me, the Truth, the Way,
Far brighter than that sun in May.

THAMES WALK

I stroll in Chiswick, graves on my right hand,
Where Hogarth sleeps and Whistler took his stand.
The Thames lies left, where eager rowers glide,
Their focus sharp as cormorants beside;
Perched high and still, intent upon their prey,
In silence marking out the dawning day.

Above, black poplars sway in winds that guide
The fallen chestnuts on the towpath side.
I greet a walker with a cheerful say,
Who mutters of the rain's impending grey;
Such gloom presages futures full of dread,
A heavy cloud that hangs above the head.

Yet here Gustav Holst knew winter's long embrace,
And found the Thames held ever constant grace.
While man debates his intellect's great span,

Nature persists, unfazed by plots of man.
The river's rise and fall, the bees at work,
Go on as human efforts rise and shirk.
Birds group in flocks, a unity of mind,
While we debate what makes us so defined.

I feel the breeze and turn to gardens near,
Where ducks and geese in tranquil grace appear.
By Burlington's grand house, I am in awe;
The sun casts dappled light, without a flaw,
Upon the earth, the water, and the tree:
A painter's touch, as far as eyes can see.

In parish grounds, upon a stone I write,
While leaves swirl round like monks in windy flight.
Here Hogarth lies beneath his lasting tomb,
Beside a soul who knows a living gloom:
A homeless man, worn thin by cold despair,
With naught to shield him from the biting air.
Art honours one with fame that never ends,

While poverty the other's spirit bends;
And so, with this, my time in Chiswick ends,
Where beauty, sorrow, and the river blend.

UPON THE VIADUCT OF TAVISTOCK

Upon the granite arch of Tavistock,
The train once halted at the station clock;
Where men and women in their Victorian frocks,
Bartered the soul for silver and livestock.
The ancient town has earthly goods in stock,
A market hoard beneath the viaduct.

But I prefer the railroad upturned,
To Romance where the lessons are unlearned;
Nature takes her righteous comeuppance,
Upon the ruins of old Civilisation's stance.
The passage now possesses but a brook,
That flickers like the pages of a book;
A soft glow of flames, a travel back in time,
Brighter than emerald, ancient and sublime.

I spot a bench perched high and far ahead,
Where priests once led the procession of the dead;
Victorian spirits live beneath the leaves,
Within the giant oak trees and the eaves.
And there the poet feels a strange relief,
To meet, at last, the instance of belief.

AT THE ABBEY WEIR

The angels brush their wings against the wind,
As night absolves the water of its sinned
And heavy currents.
Rain has filled the weir;
The bubbles burst, the crashing waters shear
The white foam from the dark and cackling tide,
Where chaos and the ancient torrents ride;
A roar that gathers from the river's birth
To race like curses to the ends of earth.

The bridge is damp, the stone is mildewed green,
The water smashes like a brute unseen;
It rises underneath the arches high,
A tidal surge beneath the winter sky.

But back again, upon the rapids' face,
The Angels descend with a fearless grace;

They dance upon the white and foaming sheet,
Where violence and holy promise meet.
'Behold!' they howl, 'The Bridegroom comes to
save!
To walk upon the water and the grave.
Nature herself soars up in wild delight
To turn the heart toward the eternal light.'

I listen close against the river stone
And hear the whisper meant for me alone:
'The flesh is weak, the Spirit reigns above,
Sustained within the Majesty of Love.
The night draws near, the end is close at hand,
But Heaven hears the crying of the land.'